This Patient Group Direction (PGD)is intended only for registered healthcare professionals who have been named and authorised by their organisation to practice under it.

Patient Group Direction
for the administration of Benzoyl Peroxide plus Clindamycin or Adapalene plus Benzoyl Peroxide for the treatment of Acne Vulgaris

Patient Group Direction, version 006, issued 30 September 2026. Supersedes Version 005, 14 September 2026.

Owner and authorising organisation: Get Real Health Limited, company number 12744898, registered office Zenvite Health Unit 23, St. Asaph Business Park, St. Asaph, Denbighshire, LL17 0LJ. This Patient Group Direction is authorised on behalf of Get Real Health Limited by its Medical Director and its Head Pharmacist, whose signatures for this version are on the authorisation page at the end of the document. It applies to the registered healthcare professionals named under it by a pharmacy or clinic that has adopted it through a Get Real Health service agreement, at the premises stated in that adoption, and to no other organisation.

Summary of NICE / NICE CKS Guidelines for Acne

Overview

- **Acne vulgaris** is a chronic inflammatory skin condition affecting the **pilosebaceous units**, typically on the **face**, **back**, and **chest**.
- Common in adolescents but can persist into adulthood.

Assessment

Types of Lesions

- **Comedones** (open = blackheads; closed = whiteheads)

- **Inflammatory lesions** (papules, pustules, nodules, cysts)
- Assess for:
    - **Severity** (mild, moderate, severe)
    - **Scarring** or **psychological distress**
    - Duration and previous treatments

Red Flags – Consider Referral

- Severe nodulocystic acne
- Risk of or presence of **scarring**
- Significant **psychological impact**
- No response to ≥2 standard treatments over 6 months

Management – First-Line Treatment (Based on Severity)

Severity	Treatment	Duration
Mild acne	Topical **retinoid** (e.g. adapalene) + topical **benzoyl peroxide**	At least **12 weeks**
Moderate acne	Topical **retinoid + benzoyl peroxide**, OR	
Topical **antibiotic + benzoyl peroxide**	Avoid monotherapy	
Severe or widespread acne	Oral **antibiotic** (e.g. doxycycline or lymecycline) + topical **retinoid or benzoyl peroxide**	Limit oral antibiotics to **12 weeks**

Do **not** combine oral and topical antibiotics to avoid resistance.

Alternative and Specialist Options

- **Oral contraceptives** (for females with hormonal acne)
    - Consider **co-cyprindiol** if acne is unresponsive and other methods are unsuitable.
- **Isotretinoin** (oral retinoid): for **severe, scarring, or resistant acne**, **specialist only** due to teratogenicity and psychiatric risk.

General Advice and Skin Care

- Cleanse skin gently twice daily with a non-comedogenic cleanser.
- Avoid picking or squeezing lesions.
- Advise that treatment takes **at least 6–8 weeks** to show improvement.
- Use **non-comedogenic** skincare and cosmetics.

Follow-Up and Referral

- Review after 8–12 weeks to assess response.
- **Refer to dermatology** if:
  - Moderate-to-severe acne not responding to treatment
  - Scarring or pigmentation developing
  - Isotretinoin is being considered

Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

Benzoyl peroxide plus Clindamycin

for the treatment of

Acne Vulgaris

Healthcare professionals covered and training

	Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements
Qualifications and Registration	● Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC ● Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC
Training and assessment	• Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team. ● All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines ● All users must have completed training in working under Patient Group Directions, for example the CPPE PGD e-learning and e-assessment or an equivalent, and have been assessed as competent to work under a PGD before first working under this one; previous experience of working under a PGD is not required ● All users should complete the Get Real Health training for this PGD before first working under it, or have completed equivalent training elsewhere, for example another provider's training for the same service or substantial recent experience of delivering it under a PGD, and must read this PGD in full before first working under it. The date the training was completed, and for equivalent training what it was, is to be recorded in the Get Real Health training record or in the employing organisation's own training record. The employing organisation remains responsible for being satisfied that each practitioner it authorises under this PGD is competent to do so. ● Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer ● All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service

Further training and responsibilities	● All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal ● All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products ● All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

PGD Indication	Benzoyl Peroxide plus Clindamycin is indicated for the topical treatment of mild to moderate acne vulgaris in individuals aged 12 years and over, particularly where comedones, papules and pustules are present.
Inclusion criteria	- Individuals aged 12 years and over. - Clinical diagnosis of mild to moderate acne vulgaris. - Informed consent obtained. - No contraindications to ingredients.
Exclusion criteria	- Known hypersensitivity to clindamycin, lincomycin, or benzoyl peroxide. - History of antibiotic-associated colitis. - Severe acne requiring systemic therapy. - Broken or inflamed skin at application site. - Pregnancy or breastfeeding. Refer to the GP (safety in pregnancy is not established; clindamycin is found in breast milk and the product must never be applied to the breast area).
Cautions	- Avoid contact with eyes, mouth, mucous membranes, or broken skin. In the case of accidental contact, rinse well with water. - Use sunscreen and limit sun exposure due to increased sensitivity. - Monitor for signs of skin irritation; discontinue if severe. - Use caution in patients with a history of gastrointestinal disease. - Use with caution in atopic patients. - Consider referral to dermatologist if acne is causing severe scarring, persistent pigmentary changes or is contributing to persistent psychological distress or a mental health disorder.
Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment	Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate

Details of the medicine

Name, form and strength of medicine	Clindamycin 10mg/g plus benzoyl peroxide 30mg/g gel, and clindamycin 10mg/g plus benzoyl peroxide 50mg/g gel (Duac)
Legal category	POM
Storage	Store in a refrigerator (2°C–8°C) before dispensing. Once dispensed, store below 25°C and use within 2 months.
Route/method of administration	Topical application to affected area once daily in the evening. Should be applied in a thin film after washing gently with a mild cleanser and fully drying. If the gel does not rub into the skin easily, too much is being applied. Patients should be advised that excessive application will not improve efficacy but may increase the risk of skin irritation. If excessive dryness or peeling occurs, frequency of application should be reduced or

	application temporarily interrupted. Hands should be washed after application.
Dose and frequency	Apply a thin layer to the entire affected area once daily in the evening. A clinical decision must be made on the strength of gel to be used. The 10mg/g + 30mg/g strength is suitable for mild to moderate presentations and minimizes risk of skin reactions. Where the lower strength has proven less effective, for more moderate presentations or where a patient has previously tolerated 50mg/g (5%) benzoyl peroxide, the 10mg/g + 50mg/g may be preferred.
Quantity to be administered and/or supplied	Up to 1 x 30 g tube per treatment course.
Maximum or minimum treatment period	Maximum of 12 weeks continuous use; review required for repeat courses. NICE recommends at least 12 weeks for a first-line course, so a patient who needs the full course is reviewed at 12 weeks before any further supply.
Adverse effects	Dryness, peeling, redness, burning, and irritation of the skin. Rare: diarrhoea, colitis due to clindamycin absorption. Refer to SmPC. Application site reactions including skin and hair discoloration.

Yellow card reporting	Report suspected adverse effects via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP as appropriate.
Records to be kept	Record the following information: ● that valid informed consent was given ● name of individual, address, date of birth and GP ● name of healthcare practitioner ● name and brand of medication ● date of supply, dose, form, route and quantity supplied ● advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment ● details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken ● that the medicine was supplied via PGD Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made. A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows: ● Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years ● Children aged under 18 years - keep records until the 25th birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26th birthday)

Patient information

Written information to be given to patient or carer	Supply the patient information leaflet (PIL) provided with the medication.
Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer	Seek advice if the skin reaction is severe (marked redness, peeling, burning or swelling), or if there is no improvement after 8 to 12 weeks of regular use. Improvement is not expected before 6 to 8 weeks. Avoid over-cleaning acne-prone skin. Avoid oil-based comedogenic skin care products, make-up and sunscreens, and if make-up is used it must be removed at the end of the day. Persistent picking or scratching of lesions can increase the risk of scarring. Treatments may take 6-8 weeks to be effective and may irritate the skin, especially at the start of treatment.

Key references

- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions. Published March 2017 https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mg2
- NICE MPG2 Patient group directions: competency framework for health professionals using patient group directions. Updated March 2017 https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2/resources
- NICE CKS Guidance
- British National Formulary (BNF) Key information on the selection, prescribing, dispensing and administration of medicines BNF (British National Formulary) | NICE
- Summary of Product Characteristics for drug

Agreement to practise by the Registered Healthcare Professional

By signing this PGD you are confirming that you agree to its contents and that you will work within it. PGDs do not remove inherent professional obligations or accountability. It is the responsibility of each healthcare professional to practise only within the bounds of their own competence and professional code of conduct.

Name and address of pharmacy premises / clinic premises to which this PGD relates			
Name of healthcare professional	**Job title**	**Registration number**	**Signature**

Valid from date		Expiry date	
30/9/26		31/7/27	

PGD adoption and authorisation by the employer/clinical lead

The employer has ensured that the person using this PGD, has the knowledge and skills to safely provide the service which will encompass the supply or administration of a medication or medicine.

This section must be signed by the superintendent or clinical lead responsible for this service. To be completed by the adopting pharmacy. These are the adopting organisation's own signatories and must not be Get Real Health staff.

Name of superintendent / clinical lead	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date
Name of professional group signatory	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date

Change history to version 001

Later versions are recorded in the Version and change record at the end of this document.

Version number	Change details	Date
001	Development & issue of new PGD	1st November 2025

Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

Adapalene plus Benzoyl Peroxide

for the treatment of

Acne Vulgaris

Healthcare professionals covered and training

	Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements
Qualifications and Registration	● Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC ● Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC
Training and assessment	• Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team. ● All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines ● All users must have completed training in working under Patient Group Directions, for example the CPPE PGD e-learning and e-assessment or an equivalent, and have been assessed as competent to work under a PGD before first working under this one; previous experience of working under a PGD is not required ● All users should complete the Get Real Health training for this PGD before first working under it, or have completed equivalent training elsewhere, for example another provider's training for the same service or substantial recent experience of delivering it under a PGD, and must read this PGD in full before first working under it. The date the training was completed, and for equivalent training what it was, is to be recorded in the Get Real Health training record or in the employing organisation's own training record. The employing organisation remains responsible for being satisfied that each practitioner it authorises under this PGD is competent to do so. ● Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer ● All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service

Further training and responsibilities	● All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal ● All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products ● All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

PGD Indication	Adapalene and benzoyl peroxide gel is indicated for the topical treatment of mild to moderate acne vulgaris in individuals aged 12 years and over, especially where comedones and inflammatory lesions are present.
Inclusion criteria	- Individuals aged 12 years and over. - Diagnosis of mild to moderate acne vulgaris suitable for topical treatment. - Informed consent obtained. - No contraindications to adapalene or benzoyl peroxide.
Exclusion criteria	- Known hypersensitivity to adapalene, benzoyl peroxide, or any excipients. - Severe acne requiring systemic treatment. - Presence of eczema, broken or sunburned skin at the application site. - Pregnancy or planning pregnancy.
Cautions	- Avoid contact with eyes, mouth, mucous membranes, and broken skin. - Advise patient to use sunscreen and limit sun exposure. - Apply once daily in the evening and wash hands after use. - Discontinue if excessive irritation or allergic reaction occurs. - If product enters the eye, wash immediately with warm water. - Caution should be exercised if cosmetics with irritant or drying effects are used, as they may produce additive irritant effects with the medicinal product. - Avoid contact with any coloured material including hair and dyed fabrics as this may result in bleaching and discoloration. - A decision must be made whether to discontinue breast-feeding weighing up the benefit of breast-feeding for the child against the benefit of therapy for the woman. To avoid contact exposure of the infant, application to the chest should be avoided if used during breast-feeding. A risk to the suckling child cannot be excluded.
Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment	Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate

Details of the medicine

Name, form and strength of medicine	Adapalene and benzoyl peroxide 0.1% / 2.5% and 0.3% / 2.5% gel
Legal category	POM
Storage	Store below 25°C. Do not freeze.

Route/method of administration	Topical application to affected area once daily in the evening.
Dose and frequency	Apply a thin layer to the entire affected area once daily in the evening to clean and dry skin.
Quantity to be administered and/or supplied	Up to 1 x 30 g tube or pump per treatment course.
Maximum or minimum treatment period	Initial treatment for up to 12 weeks; reassess if longer use is required. If no improvement is observed after 4-8 weeks of treatment, the benefit of continued treatment should be considered
Adverse effects	Skin irritation, dryness, redness, peeling, burning. Rare: hypersensitivity reactions. Refer to SmPC.

Yellow card reporting	Report suspected adverse effects via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP as appropriate.
Records to be kept	Record the following information: ● that valid informed consent was given ● name of individual, address, date of birth and GP ● name of healthcare practitioner ● name and brand of medication ● date of supply, dose, form, route and quantity supplied ● advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment ● details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken ● that the medicine was supplied via PGD Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made. A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows: ● Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years ● Children aged under 18 years - keep records until the 25th birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26th birthday)

Patient information

Written information to be given to patient or carer	Supply the patient information leaflet (PIL) provided with the medication.
Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer	Seek advice if the skin reaction is severe (marked redness, peeling, burning or swelling), or if there is no improvement after 4 to 8 weeks of regular use

	(per the SmPC). To avoid over-cleaning the skin (which may cause dryness and irritation). Acne is not caused by poor hygiene. To use a non-alkaline (skin pH neutral or slightly acidic) cleansing product twice daily on acne-prone skin. To avoid oil-based skin care products, make-up and sunscreens, and if make-up is used to remove it at the end of the day. That persistent picking or scratching of lesions can increase the risk of scarring. That treatments may irritate the skin, especially at the start of treatment. To reduce the risk of skin irritation to start with alternate-day or short-contact application (for example washing off after an hour). That there is not enough evidence to support specific diets for treating acne, but that it is important to maintain a healthy diet.

Key references

- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions. Published March 2017 https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mg2
- NICE MPG2 Patient group directions: competency framework for health professionals using patient group directions. Updated March 2017 https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2/resources
- NICE CKS Guidance
- British National Formulary (BNF) Key information on the selection, prescribing, dispensing and administration of medicines BNF (British National Formulary) | NICE
- Summary of Product Characteristics for drug

Agreement to practise by the Registered Healthcare Professional

By signing this PGD you are confirming that you agree to its contents and that you will work within it. PGDs do not remove inherent professional obligations or accountability. It is the responsibility of each healthcare professional to practise only within the bounds of their own competence and professional code of conduct.

Name and address of pharmacy premises / clinic premises to which this PGD relates			
Name of healthcare professional	Job title	Registration number	Signature

Valid from date		Expiry date	
30/9/26		31/7/27	

PGD adoption and authorisation by the employer/clinical lead

The employer has ensured that the person using this PGD, has the knowledge and skills to safely provide the service which will encompass the supply or administration of a medication or medicine.

This section must be signed by the superintendent or clinical lead responsible for this service. To be completed by the adopting pharmacy. These are the adopting organisation's own signatories and must not be Get Real Health staff.

Name of superintendent / clinical lead	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date
Name of professional group signatory	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date

Change history to version 001

Later versions are recorded in the Version and change record at the end of this document.

Version number	Change details	Date
001	Development & issue of new PGD	1st November 2025

Version and change record

Version: v006

Issued: 30 September 2026

Supersedes: Version 005, 14 September 2026

Valid from: 30 September 2026. Expiry: 31 July 2027. These dates govern this version and supersede any earlier date printed elsewhere in this document.

Changes in this version:

Training before first use, applied to every Get Real Health PGD on 30 September 2026: the staff section now states that each practitioner should complete the Get Real Health training for this PGD, or equivalent training elsewhere, before first working under it, must read the PGD in full before first use, and that the date of completion is recorded. Training is recorded; it is not a condition of access, and the employing organisation remains responsible for being satisfied of competence. No clinical content changes.

Previous version records

Version: v005

Issued: 14 September 2026

Supersedes: Version 004, 11 September 2026

Valid from: 14 September 2026. Expiry: 31 July 2027. These dates govern this version and supersede any earlier date printed elsewhere in this document.

Changes in this version:

Identity and training, applied to every Get Real Health PGD on 14 September 2026 after two adopting pharmacies wrote: the Get Real Health logo is in the page header; the organisation that owns and authorises this direction, Get Real Health Limited, is named under the strapline with its company number and registered office; the requirement that practitioners must previously have used a PGD is replaced by a requirement for PGD training and a competence assessment, so that a newly registered pharmacist or technician who has completed the training may work under it; and the earlier change history table is headed with the versions it covers.

Previous version records

Version: v004

Issued: 11 September 2026

Supersedes: Version 003, 11 September 2026

Valid from: 11 September 2026. Expiry: 31 July 2027. These dates govern this version and supersede any earlier date printed elsewhere in this document.

Changes in this version:

Duac exclusion criteria: the SmPC prose on pregnancy and breastfeeding is replaced by a plain exclusion with referral, which is how it was already applied.

Duac medicine row: each strength now names its components (clindamycin 10mg/g; benzoyl peroxide 30 or 50 mg/g).

Duac treatment-period row: states that the 12-week PGD maximum equals the NICE course minimum, so the 12-week review precedes any further supply.

Follow-up advice: each arm now states only its own review interval (Duac 8 to 12 weeks; Epiduo 4 to 8 weeks).

Epiduo cautions: apply at night changed to once daily in the evening, matching the dose row.

Records row: spacing typo in the under-18 retention bullet corrected.

Records row: the two run-together bullets were separated and punctuated (date of supply, dose, form, route and quantity supplied; adverse reactions and actions taken; supplied via PGD).

Wording corrections from the tool alignment and adversarial review of the consultation tools, 11 September 2026. Each correction resolves a contradiction inside the document or a plain error, taking the safer reading; no indication is widened, no dose raised and no exclusion removed. Questions that need a clinical decision are recorded separately and are not changed here.

Previous version records

Version: v003

Issued: 11 September 2026

Supersedes: Version 002, 10 September 2026

Valid from: 11 September 2026. Expiry: 31 July 2027. These dates govern this version and supersede any earlier date printed elsewhere in this document.

Changes in this version:

Structural clean-up applied to every live Get Real Health PGD on 11 September 2026, following the adversarial review of 10 September: the adopting pharmacy's authorisation block is blank, for the pharmacy's own signatories; one signed authorisation page for this version replaces the earlier signature blocks; every validity cell states this version's dates (valid from 11 September 2026, expiry 31 July 2027); narration about earlier versions, the consultation tool and individual customers is removed from the body of the document; the change records of earlier reissues are carried below as previous version records. No clinical criterion changes unless listed.

Previous version records

Version: v002

Issued: 10 September 2026

Supersedes: Version 001, 1 November 2025

Valid from: 10 September 2026. Expiry: 31 July 2027. These dates govern this version and supersede any earlier date printed elsewhere in this document.

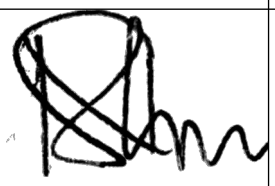
Changes in this version:

Validity: this version is valid from 10 September 2026 and expires on 31 July 2027.

Follow-up advice, both arms: the line telling the patient to seek advice if not improved in 3 to 4 weeks was a template sentence from an infection PGD. The same page says treatment takes 6 to 8 weeks and the guidance says review at 8 to 12 weeks. Replaced with the review interval for each product.

Signed on behalf of Get Real Health

Version v006, 30 September 2026.

Name	Qualification	Signature	Date
Nitin Shori	Medical Director GMC: 6047293		30 September 2026
Chris Pilkington	Head Pharmacist GPhC: 2046322		30 September 2026

Both authorising signatories reviewed this version together on 30 September 2026 and gave their authorisation for it to be issued. Signatures were applied digitally on their joint instruction, which is the established process for Get Real Health PGDs. This version is not valid without both signatures.